



Aswath becomes India's 98th Grandmaster



For Aswath S, chess began at home. His father, A.C. Shiva, was his first coach; the family academy stood above their house in Kanyakumari, and his mother now trains players at Cape Chess Academy in Nagercoil.

That childhood path reached its biggest milestone when the 17-year-old completed the requirements to become India's 98th Grandmaster, scoring his final GM norm at the Pune International Grandmaster Round Robin.

Aswath, who needed a win in the last round, beat USA's FM Kannan Vaidyanathan with the black pieces to finish with 7/9. It completed a strong late surge after he had only 1.5 points from the first three rounds. He then won his final three games, including victories over GM Aleksej Aleksandrov and IM Akshay Borgaonkar.

Aswath's first norm came at the Grenke Open A 2025 in Germany, and his second at the First Saturday GM Round Robin in Budapest.

JAYANTHO SENGUPTA

» INDIA PLAYGROUND

SPORTOON



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Telangana will host the 2026 edition of Khelo India Youth Games,

Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya announced. The KIYG is likely to take place in November. "In keeping with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision to spread major national events in all regions of the country, it is appropriate that Telangana should get the opportunity to host the prestigious Khelo India Youth Games. The state has the infrastructure and the enthusiasm to host these Games where at least 8000 athletes, officials and support staff are expected to participate," said Mandaviya.

TEAM SPORTSTAR

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The World Padel League (WPL) will be held in Mumbai in August, with

six franchise teams featuring several leading international players. The fourth season, to be held at the SVP Stadium from August 12 to 16, will feature more than 36 players from five countries, including Spain, Argentina and Brazil. Former Indian tennis player Mahesh Bhupathi, co-founder of the World Padel League, said he was happy to see the growth of the sport in the country. "India is fast becoming one of padel's most exciting growth stories globally," said Bhupathi.

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